FREE PARENT CHECKLIST

Is My Child Struggling to Learn?

A checklist for spotting learning difficulties early

Dyslexia, dysgraphia and dyscalculia signs by age, what else it could be, and what helps.

eMbrace Lives

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START HERE

Is my child struggling, or struggling to learn?

Plenty of bright, hard-working children find reading, writing or maths unusually hard. It is rarely about effort or intelligence. This checklist helps you spot patterns that may point to a learning difficulty, so support can begin early.

This is a checklist, not a diagnosis

Only a qualified clinician can identify a learning disability, through a psychoeducational assessment. Use this to organise your observations before you speak to the school or a professional.

What are specific learning difficulties?

Specific learning disabilities (SLD) are neurodevelopmental differences that make it harder to learn particular skills despite average or above-average intelligence, good teaching and effort. They are recognised in India under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016.

Dyslexia

Difficulty with accurate, fluent reading and spelling. Linked to how the brain processes the sounds of language.

Dysgraphia

Difficulty with handwriting, spelling and organising thoughts on paper, despite understanding the content.

Dyscalculia

Difficulty understanding numbers, quantity, and maths facts or procedures, beyond ordinary maths anxiety.

A few important truths

Learning difficulties are **not** caused by laziness, poor parenting or low intelligence. They often run in families, may co-occur with ADHD or anxiety, and respond very well to the right teaching approach.

SELF-CHECK

Checklist by stage

Tick what you see often, beyond what is expected for the age, and in spite of good effort. Fill in the section closest to your child's age.

Preschool and kindergarten (ages 3–6)

- ☐ Late talking, or trouble learning nursery rhymes and rhyming words
- ☐ Difficulty learning letters, colours, days of the week
- ☐ Mixes up similar-sounding words or mispronounces long words
- ☐ Struggles with fine motor tasks like holding a crayon or using scissors
- ☐ Family history of reading or learning difficulties

Early primary (grades 1–3)

- ☐ Slow to connect letters with sounds; reads very slowly or guesses words
- ☐ Reverses or confuses letters (b/d, p/q) well beyond the early stage
- ☐ Spelling is inconsistent, even for common words
- ☐ Avoids reading aloud
- ☐ Struggles to remember number facts or counts on fingers long after peers
- ☐ Handwriting is very effortful or hard to read

Upper primary and middle school (grades 4–8)

- [ ] Reads below grade level; avoids long texts
- [ ] Understands things well when told but struggles to show it in writing
- [ ] Written work is short, disorganised or full of spelling errors
- [ ] Maths word problems and multi-step procedures are very hard
- [ ] Takes much longer than others to finish homework
- [ ] Difficulty copying from the board or taking notes

Secondary school and teens (grade 9 and up)

- [ ] Reading and writing remain slow and tiring
- [ ] Problems organising essays or finishing exams on time
- [ ] Strong ideas in discussion but weak results on paper
- [ ] Relies heavily on memory or others to cope
- [ ] Difficulty learning other languages, which is common in multilingual schools

Emotional and daily signs (any age)

- [ ] Says "I'm stupid" or "I can't do it"
- [ ] Complains of stomach aches or headaches before school
- [ ] Acts out or becomes the class clown to avoid work
- [ ] Withdraws, or becomes anxious about homework and tests
- [ ] Teachers say "bright but not working to potential"

MAKING SENSE OF IT

What your ticks might mean

Ticks in a stage	What to do
0–3, mostly emotional	Keep observing and talk to the teacher. Try the home strategies on the next pages.
4 or more, over 6+ months	Raise it with the school and consider a professional opinion. Early support helps most.
4 or more, plus emotional signs or falling grades	Book a psychoeducational assessment. Do not wait for the child to "catch up".

Is it a learning difficulty or something else?

Could also be…	Clues
Vision or hearing problems	Squinting, sitting close to the board, not responding when called. A simple eye and hearing check is worth doing first.
Language of instruction mismatch	Child understands at home in one language but struggles at school in another. Assessment should consider all languages used.
ADHD	Attention drops across all tasks, not only reading or maths; often co-occurs with learning difficulties.
Anxiety	Performance falls when under pressure or fear of failure, and is better in relaxed settings.
Gaps in teaching or missed school	Skills improve quickly with good catch-up instruction. Learning difficulties persist despite it.
Giftedness with boredom	Bright, but disengaged. Strong in some areas, with weak written output.

Many children have more than one thing going on. A thorough assessment looks at all of them together.

GETTING SUPPORT

What helps, at home and at school

At home

Read together daily, even with older children. Let them listen to audiobooks to keep up with stories.

Practise in short, multisensory bursts: tracing letters in sand, building words with blocks.

Praise effort and strategy, not only results.

Protect self-esteem: highlight strengths in art, sport, speaking, or problem solving.

Break homework into 10–15 minute blocks with breaks.

At school

Request extra time, a reader or scribe, or use of a laptop for written work where appropriate.

Ask for explicit, step-by-step teaching of reading, spelling or maths.

Agree on fewer copying tasks and more oral responses.

Seek a regular check-in with a special educator or counsellor.

Ask about language exemptions where relevant.

What a psychoeducational assessment includes

- **Cognitive testing** (such as the WISC-V) to understand how your child thinks and learns.
- **Achievement testing** for reading, writing and maths, compared with ability.
- **Screening for attention, anxiety and language** factors that affect learning.
- **A written report** with a clear profile and recommendations, usable for school accommodations.

A note on accommodations

Boards and schools in India commonly allow accommodations such as extra time, a reader or scribe, or language exemptions for children with a documented difficulty. Rules differ by board and change over time, so check the current circular and ask the school for support early, well before board years.

PRINT AND FILL IN

Learning observation log

For two weeks, jot down what you notice during homework and reading. Bring it, along with school notebooks, to your consultation.

Task (reading, writing, maths, homework)	What was hard	Time it took / help needed	How my child felt

Questions to bring

- Is this a gap in teaching, or a pattern that needs assessment?
- Can the school share class tests and teacher observations?
- How does my child do in oral work compared with written?
- Which strengths can we build on?

NEXT STEP

Take the next step with eMbrace

A quiet word with a specialist can change a school year.

If your checklist shows a pattern, a psychoeducational assessment can explain how your child learns and unlock the right help. Our team assesses and supports children in person at both centres, and online.

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Assessment	embracelives.com/learning-disabilities/learning-disability-assessment

Important information

This checklist is for general education only. It does not diagnose learning disabilities or replace professional assessment.
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